

The fact is people engage in partnerships for the wrong reasons. Like people start businesses under false premises (not need-oriented), they also form partnerships under a similar false premise: *Diversification*. The partners don't seek synergy; they seek diversification of risk, expense, and workload. Often, each partner looks to the other for the burden to bear, and when one bears more, resentment builds.

Partnerships can work, just like a lot of marriages work. Just make sure you know whom you're engaged to. A two-week honeymoon with your college roommate might not be enough courtship to determine compatibility. Would you marry someone after two weeks of dating?

GET A+ A'S

I've had many verbal negotiations with investors, and when the 90-page legalese document arrived on my desk, what was said and what was written were two different things. We discussed an amortized note at 10% over 5 years, so why does it say 5% over 10? Who exposed the incongruity buried in an avalanche of legal jargon? Not me. It was my attorney.

Then there was the time when a simple omission of a business expense can cost you thousands of dollars in taxes. Who knows that \$38,000 interactive voice response system is depreciable when you think it's just some overpriced telephone system? An accountant.

If I didn't have good team of A's—*accountants* and *attorneys*—I'd be poorer. And yes, these people aren't easy to find because they're like partners under contract, another group of individuals who have the keys to your castle.

Don't be an idiot like me. Still green, I remember my first accountant, found right out of the Yellow Pages—not from referral, but blind hope. It didn't take long to see that she wasn't concerned with tax planning. No questions about my business or my concerns, just zeal to complete the forms and get it done. Additionally, most of her clients were Slowlaners who dabbled with w-2s and 401ks rather than corporations. Great pick, MJ. I needed someone with a Fastlane business mindset, and I committed to finding one. After interviewing and investigating a half-dozen accountants, I found one whose clients were primarily business owners.

Be very careful with whom you trust with the keys to your castle because they can drive you to financial ruin. Remember Nicolas Cage; his manager allegedly drove him to the precipice of financial ruin. Investigate and interview. Get referrals from successful, established entrepreneurs. Treat your two A's like you would any partner, because they have unfettered access to your castle, and those with the keys have the potential to steer you wrong.

WOULD YOU LIKE A CHAINSAW WITH YOUR BEER?

When you blindly trust others to anything—business, financial investments, security—you're vulnerable to being conned.